PRINTABLE KIT · 8 PAGES

BEFORE YOU VISIT YOUR PARENTS THIS SEASON

Home for the Holidays: Is It Time?

A quiet way to notice whether a parent needs more help, three conversations that don't start a fight, and a plan for the drive home.

WHAT'S INSIDE

- How to use this weekend
- 36 signs across six areas
- The kitchen walk
- Three conversations that work
- What not to say
- The family debrief
- Green, yellow, red: what to do next
- Next steps tracker

START HERE

How to use this weekend

You're not there to inspect. You're there for the holiday. This kit lets you notice things while you're carving the turkey, and gives you words for the conversation if you need them.

Before you go

- [ ] Read the 36 signs once so they're in the back of your mind
- [ ] Pick one sibling or relative to compare notes with afterward
- [ ] Decide: this visit is for noticing, not fixing
- [ ] Print the debrief page; keep it in the car

While you're there

- [ ] Offer to cook or clean up. The kitchen tells you the most.
- [ ] Ride along somewhere if they drive
- [ ] Look at the mail pile and the pill bottles without commenting
- [ ] Notice how they move from chair to kitchen to bathroom
- [ ] Mark the signs page privately, later, not in front of them

The three rules

1. One thing at a time. If you see twelve problems, you still raise one. The conversation you want to have is the first of several, not the only one.

2. Curious, not corrective. "I noticed the stairs seemed harder this year" opens a door. "You shouldn't be using those stairs" closes it. Scripts on page 5.

3. Their life, their say. Unless safety is immediate, the goal is to be invited in, not to take over. Parents who feel managed start hiding things.

If you see something that can't wait

A burn or fall they didn't mention, spoiled food they're eating, medications badly mixed up, a car with new dents, confusion about who you are. Skip to page 7. Those are red, and red means this week, not after New Year's.

MARK PRIVATELY, AFTER

36 signs, six areas

Fine · Not sure / small change · Noticed clearly

The house

Upkeep slips before anything else.

- [ ] Clutter or mail piling up where it didn't before
- [ ] Dishes, laundry, or bathroom noticeably less clean
- [ ] Burned pots, scorch marks, a smoke detector with no battery
- [ ] Lights out, repairs undone, yard let go
- [ ] Rugs, cords, or stacks in the walking path
- [ ] Pets or plants not cared for the way they were

The kitchen

Food is the most honest record of a week.

- [ ] Expired or spoiled food in the fridge
- [ ] Very little fresh food; mostly cans, crackers, sweets
- [ ] Same few meals, or skipping meals
- [ ] Weight loss you can see in their clothes or face
- [ ] Multiples of the same item bought (forgot they had it)
- [ ] Stove or appliances they've stopped using

Their body

Watch how they move, not what they say.

- [ ] Holding furniture or walls to get around
- [ ] Bruises, especially arms and shins, or a fall they minimized
- [ ] Slower on stairs, or avoiding them
- [ ] Trouble hearing the conversation, or TV very loud
- [ ] Grooming slipping: hair, nails, shaving, same clothes
- [ ] Shortness of breath or new unsteadiness

Mind & mood

Repetition and withdrawal are the early tells.

- [ ] Repeating the same story or question in one visit
- [ ] Losing the thread of a conversation or a recipe they know
- [ ] Mixing up names, dates, or recent events
- [ ] Irritable, suspicious, or flat in a way that's new
- [ ] Dropped hobbies, church, friends, or calls
- [ ] Sleeping much more, or up at odd hours

Money & mail

Where exploitation shows up first.

- [ ] Unopened bills, or late notices
- [ ] Unusual purchases, subscriptions, or charity mailings
- [ ] Checks written to unfamiliar names
- [ ] Talk of a new "friend," prize, or investment
- [ ] Confusion about what's been paid
- [ ] Unusually guarded about money questions

Driving & out and about

Ask to ride along. Don't lecture in the car.

- [ ] New dents, scrapes, or a mirror knocked off
- [ ] Drifting, slow reactions, missed signs
- [ ] Getting lost on a familiar route
- [ ] Driving only in daylight, or avoiding it entirely
- [ ] Missed appointments or stopped going places
- [ ] Traffic tickets or a warning they mentioned in passing

WHILE YOU COOK OR CLEAN UP

The kitchen walk

Offer to make coffee, load the dishwasher, put leftovers away. Ten minutes in the kitchen tells you more than an hour of asking "how are you doing, really?"

LOOK AT	WHAT YOU'RE CHECKING	WHAT YOU SAW
Fridge	Dates on milk, meat, leftovers. Fresh produce present? Same containers as last visit?	
Pantry	Duplicates (three of the same jar). Mostly shelf-stable, sugary, or easy-open food?	
Stove & microwave	Scorched pans, burnt smell, splatter left for weeks, knobs they avoid.	
Counter	Pill bottles: how many, any from the same drug twice, expired dates, a pill organizer with wrong days filled.	
Mail pile	Unopened envelopes, "final notice," sweepstakes or charity mail in volume.	
Trash	Lots of takeout, or almost nothing (not eating). Broken glass or evidence of a spill nobody mentioned.	
Floor & lighting	Sticky spots, crumbs, dim bulbs, a rug that slides.	
Them, in the kitchen	Reaching high shelves, opening jars, reading labels, remembering where things go.	

Other rooms, if it's natural

Bathroom: grab bars, a slippery tub, towels, how clean. Bedroom: clear path to the bathroom, lamp within reach. Entry: can they manage the steps and the locks?

Notes

ONLY IF YOU NEED THEM

Three conversations that work

Pick one. Have it one-on-one, not at the table, not on the last morning. Say your line, then stop talking. The silence is where they answer.

1 · THE "I NOTICED" OPENER · FOR ONE SPECIFIC THING

"Mom, I noticed the stairs seemed harder this year. How are they feeling to you?"

"Dad, I saw a couple of bills on the counter from October. Want me to sit with you and go through the pile before I leave?"

Why it works: one observation, no diagnosis, a question they can answer honestly. If they brush it off, you've still planted it. Let it go for now.

2 · THE FUTURE FRAMING · FOR THE BIGGER PICTURE

"You're doing fine right now. I'm asking about later. If a day came when you needed more help at home, what would you want that to look like? Who would you want involved?"

"I'd rather know what you want while you can tell me, than guess in a hospital hallway."

Why it works: it's about their wishes, not your worries. It opens the door to paperwork (power of attorney, directives) without making it about decline.

3 · THE ASK FOR HELP · WHEN YOU NEED THEM TO ACCEPT SOMETHING

"It would honestly take a weight off me if you'd let someone come by once a week to help with the house. Would you do that for me, even if you don't think you need it?"

"Would you be willing to see Dr. ___ in January and let me come along? I'd just like to hear it from her."

Why it works: parents will do for you what they won't do for themselves. A specific, small, time-limited ask beats a general one.

What not to say

"You can't live like this." "We've decided." "You're not safe here anymore." "Remember, I told you that yesterday." Anything that starts with "You always" or "You never." Anything said in front of the grandkids.

If they get angry

"Okay. I hear you. I'm not going to push today." Then don't. You can come back to it by phone in two weeks. One hard conversation that ends calmly is worth more than winning it.

IN THE CAR, OR ON THE PHONE THAT WEEK

The family debrief

Siblings see different things and remember them differently. Compare notes within a week, while it's fresh, and agree on three next steps with names on them. Fill one copy per person, or one together.

WHO	WHAT I NOTICED (THE FACTS, NOT THE WORRY)	GREEN / YELLOW / RED

Where we agree

Where we see it differently

Three next steps, with names

STEP	WHO	BY WHEN
1.		
2.		
3.		

Things worth deciding now

- [ ] Who is the point person for Mom/Dad
- [ ] Who talks to the doctor
- [ ] Who looks at the money, if anyone
- [ ] How often we check in with each other
- [ ] What we tell Mom/Dad we're doing
- [ ] When we revisit this (date)

DECISION GUIDE

Green, yellow, red: what to do next

Count your marks from the signs page. The color isn't a diagnosis. It's how fast to move.

Green · Mostly fine, a few small changes

- [ ] Say nothing heavy. Enjoy the visit.
- [ ] Write down what you saw and the date; it's your baseline for next time
- [ ] Have conversation #2 (the future framing) sometime this year, not this weekend
- [ ] Make sure someone knows where their important papers are
- [ ] Call more often. Weekly beats quarterly for catching change.

Yellow · Several "not sure" marks, or one area clearly slipping

- [ ] Have one conversation (#1 or #3), about one thing
- [ ] Ask for a doctor's visit in the next 60 days and offer to come along; many changes have treatable causes (medications, hearing, vision, thyroid, depression, infections)
- [ ] Set up the basics: a current medication list and an emergency information sheet on the fridge
- [ ] Light help first: a cleaner every two weeks, grocery delivery, a neighbor who checks in
- [ ] Debrief with family and set a date to look again, 60 to 90 days out

Yellow is where our companion kit, *The First 30 Days*, picks up: the fridge sheet, medication list, questions for the doctor, documents checklist, and a month-long plan.

Red · Safety, health, or money is at risk now

- [ ] Falls or injuries they hid; burns; spoiled food being eaten; medications badly mixed up; confusion about who you are; a car with fresh damage; money going to a stranger
- [ ] This week: call their doctor's office, describe what you saw, ask for an urgent appointment or a home health evaluation
- [ ] Today, if it's acute (sudden confusion, a fall with pain, chest or breathing trouble): urgent care or 911
- [ ] Someone stays, or someone comes daily, until there's a plan
- [ ] Driving: if you'd be afraid to ride with them, don't let the grandkids. Say so plainly and take the keys conversation to the doctor.
- [ ] Money: freeze what you can, call the bank's elder-fraud line, and the Area Agency on Aging for Adult Protective Services guidance

AFTER THE VISIT

Next steps tracker

What you decided, who owns it, and what happened. Keep it with the debrief page and bring both to the next visit.

Visit date: _____ Overall: ☐ Green ☐ Yellow ☐ Red Look again on: _____

DATE	STEP	WHO	OUTCOME	FOLLOW-UP

What I want to remember about this visit

Questions for the doctor, if we get there

This kit helps you notice and talk. It is not medical, legal, or financial advice, and a checklist can't diagnose anything. Changes you notice deserve a conversation with your parent's doctor, who can tell the difference between normal aging and something treatable.